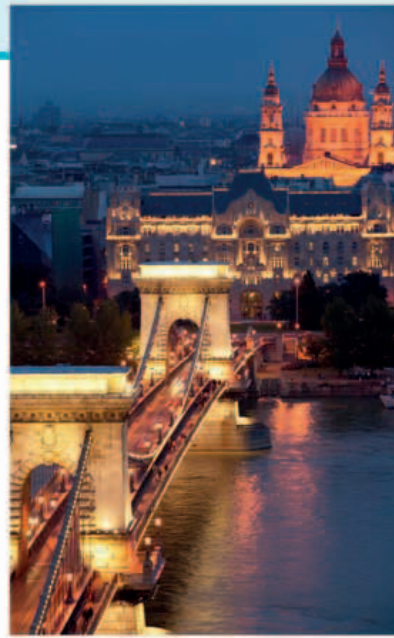




Above The 19th-century basilica of St. Stephen overlooks the Chain Bridge, which spans the Danube connecting Buda and Pest

Left Wrought-iron work and vaulting give the Great Market its spacious character



Above Paprika-hued *gulyás* (goulash) served in a metal *bogrács* cooking pot is considered an important part of Hungary's national heritage

The Great Market

Dating from the 1890s, Budapest's Great Market Hall or *Nagycsarnok* is one of the landmarks of the city, with steep-roofed corner towers giving it the air of a Transylvanian castle. Inside, cast-iron pillars preside over row upon row of stands, selling everything from fruit and veggies to embroidered blouses. Rows of salamis hang curtainlike above tins of goose-liver pâté arranged in pyramids. Many stands feature dried paprikas strung together into chains – ideal decorations for a rustic kitchen. If you're a fan of paprika in your cooking, a couple of chains will be enough to keep you going for a year or more.

The Best Places to Eat Goulash

Bock Bisztró expensive

With a bright creamy interior lined with cookbooks and wine magazines, Bock Bisztró doesn't at first sight look like the average Hungarian tavern. However, once you receive your "pre-appetizer" (a pot of spicy pork lard with plenty of crusty bread to smear it on), you quickly realize that there is more in the way of Magyar tradition here than at first meets the eye. By putting traditional national recipes and modern Mediterranean dishes on the same menu, Bock has done a great deal to make old-school Hungarian cooking fashionable again. Head chef Lajos Bíró is something of a national culinary celebrity, with several TV shows and coffee-table books to his name. Entrées like veal paprikash (*borjúpaprikás*) delight with their velvety texture and delicate paprika tones – extra spice is provided on the side if you feel the need to increase the temperature. Bock is also a wine shop, so you can get good advice on which Hungarian red to drink with your meal and the chance to buy a bottle as you leave.

Erzsebet korut 43–49, Budapest; open noon–midnight Mon–Sat; www.bockbisztro.hu

Also in Budapest

Ostentatiously decorated with Transylvanian folk motifs, 19th-century relic **Kárpátia** (www.karpatia.hu; *expensive*) is a long-established favorite with both locals and tourists, and its goulashes remain of unimpeachably high quality. Away from the tourist trail, **Régi Sípós** (www.regisipos.hu; *moderate*) serves up homey southern Hungarian delights such as carp goulash (*pontypörkölt*) or the much-prized catfish stew (*harcsapaprikás*), accompanied by lasagna-like sheets of delicious cheesy noodles.

Also in Hungary

Gulyás and *pörkölt* can be found throughout the country, but are at their best in the rural south and east. Located in Kecskemét, close to the paprika-growing plains of the south, **Kecskeméti Csárda és Borház** (+36 76 417 640; *moderate*) excels in spicy traditional cooking. The southern town of Baja is famous for its paprika-meets-fish cuisine, with riverside restaurants like **Vendio** (www.vendio.hu; *moderate*) drawing in customers with catfish stew with cheesy noodles.

Around the World

One Hungarian restaurant that is the absolute equal of any establishment in Budapest is the **Gay Hussar** (www.gayhussar.co.uk; *expensive*) in London's Soho, famous not just for its fine goulashes and duck roasts but also for a clientele that has included media types and many a leading politician over the years.